

Analogue Mechanics: Offline Brutalism

Zero Sum is designed to be played entirely offline, utilizing physical pen, paper, and physical tokens to simulate the suffocatingly real horrors of bureaucracy and hyper-capitalism. Digital tools are not required.

1. The Physical Debt Ledger

Each player is issued a **Debt Ledger Sheet**. This replaces the traditional “gold/currency” section of a character sheet. - **Red Ink and Black Ink:** Players are required to track their finances using red and black pens. Positive balances are written in black; debts are written in red. - **The Ledger as a Burden:** Every time a player buys ammo, pays a bribe, or gets billed for collateral damage, they must physically strike out their previous balance and write the new one. The paper should become messy, stressed, and overwhelming over the course of a campaign. - **Generational Debt:** When a character dies, the player does *not* throw away their Debt Ledger. They physically cross out the deceased character’s name, write their new character’s name at the top, and continue adding to the negative balance.

2. The Contract Signing (EULA)

Before any mission or major loan is granted, the GM must provide a physically printed **Standard Independent Contractor Agreement (EULA)**. - **The Ritual:** The GM slides the printed paper across the table. The players must physically sign the document with a pen. - **The Fine Print:** GMs are encouraged to hide brutal, mechanical penalties deep within the text (e.g., organ forfeiture, exorbitant interest rates, waiving rights to life-support if injured). If the players don’t read it before signing, the GM enforces the penalties mercilessly.

3. Physical Resource Tokens

Scarcity is a core theme. Numbers on a page are easily ignored, but physical tokens are not. - **Tracking:** Use pennies, poker chips, or actual metal casings to represent ammunition, and a different token to represent daily rations. - **Handing Over Tokens:** When a player fires their weapon, they must physically hand a token back to the GM. When they are out of tokens, they are out of ammo. This creates a tactile, rising panic as players watch their physical pile of survival resources dwindle.

4. The Analogue Market Crash Table

Instead of a digital ticker, the GM rolls for Market Fluctuations in front of the players at the start of every session (or whenever they visit a vendor). - **The Market Roll:** Roll a D100 on the **Market Crash Table**. - **Outcomes:** A low roll means the market is stable (prices are standard). A high roll indicates a crisis (e.g., Syndicate blockade, Corporate tax hike), applying a percentage multiplier (e.g., +50%, +200%) to all basic goods like ammo and medicine for the duration of the session.

5. The Itemized Receipt

At the end of a session, instead of simply awarding "XP and Loot," the GM physically hands each player a printed **Itemized Operational Receipt**. - The GM fills in the blanks: Gross Payout, Ammo Deductions, Bio-Hazard Cleanup, and Net Profit. - Players must then copy their Net Profit (which is often a negative number) onto their Debt Ledger in red ink.